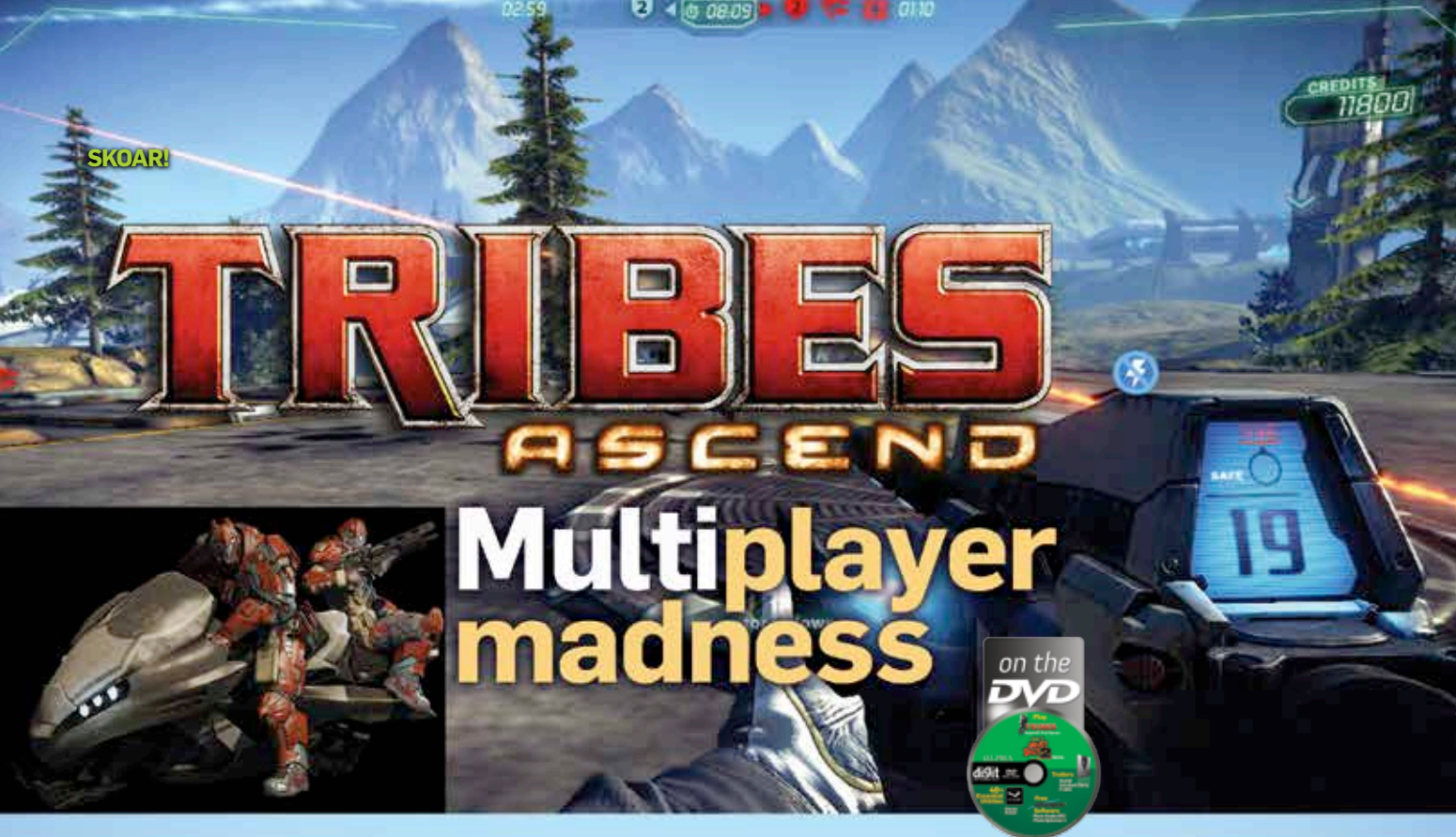




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The match is tied with only one flag cap to victory, your flag capper has just barely managed to bring the enemy flag back to your base and just as he is about to capture the enemy flag, a bolt from a Blood Eagle Pathfinder finds him and blows him to smithereens just as the enemy Pathfinder comes hurtling down from nowhere, recovers his own flag and grabs yours at over 200 km/hr, all in one, smooth, expertly choreographed motion. In the space of a second, your hopes of victory have turned to dust.

You're a Juggernaut who has just finished clearing out the generator room of pesky Raiders and as you stare at the receding figure of the enemy Pathfinder from the generator tower, your team-mates are trying to chase down the enemy. You see the blue streaks of the spinfusors in the distance, the occasional explosion of an explosive bolt and as the enemy weaves left and right amidst the chaos, narrowly but inexorably drawing further and further away, you know it won't be enough, you know that it has to be you.

You take a deep breath, indulge in mental mathematics that you never knew you were capable of, triangulate the position of the enemy, calculate his possible trajectory, point your gun at a 45 degree

angle and pull the trigger. The muted "whump" of the launch shakes your screen. The world seems to move in slow motion as you watch the mortar shell arc its way through the sky, trailing a jet of green plasma behind it. The enemy disappears behind a hillock half a kilometer away and you desperately keep your fingers crossed as the mortar follows suit, a heart-stopping moment later, WHAMMO! A massive green explosion and debris from the enemy's body gently descends to the ground as your teammates glide up to your flag and return it to its stand. You can't help but let rip a shout of pure exultation and relief amid the "Woohos" of your teammates. Being the true soldier that you are, you collect your wits, pat down your ruffled hair and smugly enter an unruffled "pwned!" in the chat box.

It is moments like these that make this free-to-play game what it is. It gives you a sense of achievement like few other titles ever have (Quake III comes to mind). Every kill, every flag capture feels good, you played the odds and came out victorious. Tribes: Ascend is not a game to be superficially glanced at and dismissed. It must be played, mastered; it is a game that demands that you sacrifice hours of your life, every single day, just to stay in shape. This isn't even drudgery, every moment is fun and the better you get at the game, the more you realize how much there is to learn. *

Verdict

To those new to the series, the gameplay is unlike anything you've ever experienced before. We won't spoil it by describing it to you, try out the game for yourself and make up your mind. It might seem tough at first, but if you persevere, you will be well rewarded. There are still issues with the game, random bugs, balance problems; but these are just small blemishes on an already well-polished title. It is testament to the quality of gameplay that we haven't even touched Quake III in these past 2 months!

NOTE: We've provided the game on our DVD; don't forget to head over to <http://dgit.in/cOnTest> for claiming special in-game freebies.

MOAR!

- »Developer: Hi-Rez Studios
- »Game Engine: Unreal Engine 3
- »Platforms: PC
- »Genre: Multiplayer FPS

